

For Your Site

If you're a business with a Web presence, you'll find the collection of Google services here interesting and perhaps useful—Google Analytics, Google Co-op, and Google Base. These services are very different from each other—there really is no linking factor, and we've grouped them here under one chapter because you'd use them if you have (or, in the case of Google Base, even want to have) a Web presence.

5.1 Google Analytics

Analytics is defined as the science of logical analysis. The Web Analytics Association defines “Web Analytics” as “the measurement, collection, analysis and reporting of Internet data for the purposes of understanding and optimising Web usage.”

Web sites are hosted on servers that keep a track of the traffic in the form of logs. The information logged varies, but usually, information like visitor IP, browser, duration of visit, link which brought visitor to the site, where the visitor headed to from the site, etc. can be logged. These logs contain a wealth of information, and identifying patterns and trends helps improve sites and eventually bottom-lines—it is crucial for any online business. While logs themselves can offer information, to be able to put them in a form that enhances comprehension is also important. Server logs can be limited by the parameters they can record or some Web site hosts just do not log all the parameters. So, the need for additional information can be satisfied by having additional code inserted in the Web page, which reports the visitor data to another server—usually with a Web analytics firm. Such firms also provide the analytical tools needed to make sense of the collected data—for a price.